

Ancient Myths, Modern Markets¹

If, following Jacques Derrida, we are to say that we inhabit the times of the “end of the book,” we would need to qualify this insight by adding that the epoch of the “end of the book” has, paradoxically enough, produced, and sold a significant number of books, sometimes with the help of an imaginative title like “national bestseller.” The phenomenon of the ‘National Bestseller’ creates and operates within a strange matrix of forces where, on the one hand, it creates a “national” reading community, but, on the other hand, the terms dictating the creation of this reading community have nothing to do with the literary tastes or aesthetic choices of the community, but rather, are predicated upon market forces that are indifferent to the question of tastes and choices, and care only about the volume of their sales. “National Bestsellers” are paradoxical, and thus symptomatic, sites where economic exchange interacts with literary production, and finance meets aesthetics.

This coveted title within the publishing industry is quite intriguing, if not symptomatic, of the networks of exchange and circulation that have come to define the “book” in the contemporary bookselling markets, including those of 21st-century India. In understanding the “production” of the best-selling mythic fiction, specifically, we can see its literary representation both influencing and being influenced by the nationalist imagination and aesthetics of contemporary India— particularly as the nation was, to use Thomas Blom Hansen's terminology, subsumed under “[the saffron wave](#).” These novels became bestsellers during a period when Indian politics was making a right-wing pivot, and, in becoming bestsellers, I would argue, they partially contributed towards *forming* the aesthetics of contemporary Hindu nationalism.

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Starting from the famous *Shiva Trilogy* by Amish Tripathi ([2010](#), [‘11](#), [‘13](#)), which arguably kick-started this genre of mythic fiction, to Ashwin Sanghi’s *Chanakya’s Chant* (2010), Sharath Komarraju’s *Hastinapur Series* ([2013](#), [‘15](#), [‘17](#)), Anand Neelakhantan’s *Asura: The Tale of the Vanquished* (2012), Krishna Udayashankar’s *The Aryavarta Chronicles* ([2012](#), [‘13](#), [‘14](#)), Anuja Chandramouli’s *Arjuna* (2013), Kavita Kane’s *Karna’s Wife: The Outcast’s Queen* (2013), *Sita’s Sister* (2014), *Lanka’s Princess* (2017), *Menaka’s Choice* (2016), *Abahya’s Awakening* (2019), Kevin Missal’s *Dharmayoddha Kalki: Avatar of Vishnu* (2018), Bhanumathi Narasimhan’s *Sita: A Tale of Ancient Love* (2021), Saiswaroop Iyer’s *Draupadi* (2019), Ranjith Radhakrishnan’s *Rama of the Axe* (2023), Akshat Gupta’s *The Hidden Hindu* trilogy ([2021](#), [‘22](#), [‘23](#)), the list of novels that have been written, and continue to be written, runs too long to give an exhaustive account.

While the length of this list represents the flourishing of “mythological fiction” as a genre, a similar quick glimpse at the (overwhelming-) market share of these books would be equally sufficient to fathom their market success. The first installment of Tripathi’s Shiva trilogy, *The Immortals of Meluha*, not only hit the bestseller list of the several newspapers, including *The Statesman*, *The Economic Times*, *The Times of India*, but was also launched with much praise by Shashi Tharoor (who himself has written a mythological fiction, *The Great Indian Novel* (1989)), and was translated into more than ten languages. The book sold more than 2.5 million copies and collected over \$7.5 million in revenue in the five years after its release. The success in fiction has also opened other doors for Tripathi, including serving as a host on a 2022 Discovery+ documentary titled [‘Legends of Ramayana with Amish,’](#) and later, on January 25, 2024, the day after the Hindu-right prompted inauguration of Ayodhya Ram Mandir, for yet another documentary titled [‘Ram Janmabhoomi: Return of a Splendid Sun.’](#)

Beyond Tripathi, whose success has been quite exceptional both within and beyond the realm of fiction, the other authors on the list have also done well in the contemporary Indian publishing

landscape. Ashwin Sanghi's *Chanakya's Chant* [won the 'Vodafone Crossword Popular Choice Award'](#) for the highest sales in 2010. Anand Neelakantan's *Asura* (2012) became a bestseller, and he went on to write [an official prequel to the pan-Indian blockbuster movie *Bahubali*](#) (2015, dir. S.S. Rajamouli). Anuja Chandramouli's *Abhimanyu: Son of Arjuna* (2022), a sequel to her *Arjuna: Saga of a Pandava Warrior-Prince* (2013), was [nominated in the popular choice category award](#) at the Bengaluru Literature Festival. Kavita Kane, a former journalist who was an assistant editor of *The Times of India*, [switched to being a full-time writer following the success](#) of her book *Karna's Wife: The Outcast Queen*. Finally, Akshat Gupta's *The Hidden Hindu* (2022) has sold over 100,000 copies, and there are [whispers that the rights for a screen adaptation](#) of Saiswaroopaa Iyer's *Avishi: Warrior Queen from the Rig Veda* (2021) have been acquired.

The early years of Anglophone writing in India has already witnessed numerous creative engagements with the theme of myth in fiction. Raja Rao's *Kanthapura* (1938) frequently draws on Indian myth to construct, evoke, and represent the native world within the language of the colonizers. His second novel, *The Serpent and the Rope* (1960), ["cash\[es\] on...appeals and attributes of the myth that are emotive, figurative, historical and also symbolic in nature."](#) In R.K. Narayan's *Malgudi Days* (1942), ["reality is given a mythical dimension,"](#) and *The Man Eater of Malgudi* (1961) features the mythological figure of Bhasmasura.

Indian poets and playwrights engage with myth as well. A.K. Ramanujan, one of the preeminent Indian poets of the last century, treated mythological narratives like *Mahabharata* ["not \[as\] as text but a tradition"](#) but as ["a part of a total world view" within Indian subcontinent](#). Arun Kolatkar and Nissim Ezekiel wrote poems with [a "sense of an awakening or discovery of mythic impulse within the socio-psychological perimeters of small-scale... self-oriented world."](#) Girish Karnad creatively used elements of myths in his *Yayati* (1961), *Nagmandala* (1990), and *The Fire and Rain* (1998). Finally,

this list would remain incomplete if we pass over the metamorphosis of myth as it appears within Salman Rushdie's magical realist novels and the ["feminist mythopoeia"](#) in the fiction of Anita Desai. Considered within this long and productive lineage, it might seem that the post-2010 boom of mythic narratives was nothing but a 21st-century manifestation, or better, reincarnation, of the myth within the lands of Indian fiction.

It would, however, be hasty to argue that the post-2010 boom of mythic fiction was nothing new, and that its narrative aesthetics were simply a continuation of the 20th-century fiction. The resurgence of right-wing politics, combined with a market-driven profile of contemporary authors, has made the current wave of bestselling mythological fiction quite a distinct literary phenomenon of our time. The authors who write "mythological narratives" have profiles that are radically different from that of the previous generation. Amish Tripathi, for example, is a graduate of IIM-Calcutta who worked in Finance for 14 years before moving into the literary world. Similarly, Ashwin Sanghi has an MBA from Yale and belongs to the family that operates "The M.K. Sanghi group" (one of the largest distributors of Indian car manufacturing). Sharath Komarajju began his life as a software engineer; Anand Neelakanthan, too, was an Engineer and worked for the Indian Oil Corporation before turning to writing fiction. Krishna Udayshankar has a Ph.D. in Strategic Management and has even published books on international management. Saiswaroop Iyer has an MBA from IIT-Kanpur, and Ramjit Radhakrishnan still works as an entrepreneur and calls himself a "proud pagan and an ardent 'idol' worshipper." From the long list of mythological fiction authors that I mentioned above, only Anuja Chandramouli and Kevin Missal are trained in the humanities. This shift in training, or academic backgrounds, of the writers of fiction has meant that the majority of mythological fiction produced in India today has been, for the most part, an anchorless enterprise lacking any foundations in literary and, thus, cultural history of the subcontinent.

Beyond these personal, biographical, and thus somewhat contingent factors, the other significant difference between the post-2010 boom and its precursors lies in the broader political formations within which these texts were written and circulated. In a 2010 interview, Amish Tripathi and Ashwin Sanghi expressed that [“when a country and its people become confident of themselves and their place in the world, they express this confidence by exploring their own inherent myths and legends.”](#) The theme of “confidence” is intriguing not only because this “confidence” echoes the discourse of “decolonial” circles which, not long ago, was much invested in the native self-respect, but, and more crucially, Tripathi and Sanghi’s remark came merely four years before the coming to power of the incumbent Hindu Nationalist party [BJP] which has similarly flourished in their native qua communal ‘confidence’ by deploying ‘myths’ for its political purposes (remind yourself here of the mythological encoding of [Advani’s 1990 “Rath Yatra,”](#) which charted its way from Somnath to Ayodhya and which would culminate, initially, in the 1992 demolition of Babri Masjid, and now with the [2024 inauguration of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya](#)). As Pankaj Mishra notes, the [“modern fascination with myth has never been free from an illiberal and anti-democratic agenda.”](#)

This particular conjecture between the right-wing political ideology *and* the market-driven literary formation has had significant influences/implications at both the level of narrative aesthetics and the literary representation of these bestselling fictional works. The most visible and immediate site where one can trace these influences— especially considering the fact that these novels take “myths” and “epics” as their foundational backdrop/structuring principle—is in their narratives, particularly how these contemporary fictional narratives use and abuse the historical narrative on which they claim to be based.

In her essay, titled “Epic and History,” Romila Thapar notes how Indian epics have [“changed their form each time they are used to mobilize support for a different ideological position.”](#) If we are

to take Thapar's historically sound insights and read the phenomena of mythological fiction through her lens, a first question arises about the entity in whose name these contemporary authors appropriate the myths in the first place. Consider Devdutt Pattanaik's observation on his art, where he notes how he ["help\[s\] people leverage the power of myths in business, management, and life."](#) This is to say, if Brahmins of the ancient world appropriated the literary epics into sacred treatises, the managerial class of contemporary authors is, in turn, appropriating these very same myths into "mantras" for the market. I am not invested here in making any morally bounded aesthetic judgment, and thus not interested in condemning the authors for their appropriation—after all, who is to say whether appropriating the narratives for gaining political and caste privilege is any better than appropriating the very same narrative to make your novels a "national bestseller"? Instead, what interests me here is the way in which the textual narratives function within these texts, and what we can potentially learn from the form of these narratives as they get (de-)formed under the pressure of literary market-place.

Indeed, many of these novels feature a near-total evacuation of history, whether in the form of "literary tradition" or as a marker of socio-political formation. Consider Tripathi's *The Immortals of Meluha*. The text is supposed to take place in 1900 BC, and yet, despite the historical marker, the narrative it creates is a strange hybrid of ancient monarchical empires, medieval feudal lords, and modern scientific sensibilities. Or, on the other end of the spectrum, Akshat Gupta's *The Hidden Hindu*, which tells the story of a twenty-one-year-old Prithvi in the contemporary timeline. Here, too, the narrative struggles to situate itself within a sense of history as the protagonist moves between the secular present and the Hindu yugas. I am not saying that mythological fiction has to pass some history test to earn its name. However, what I mean by "evacuation of past" is that these novels, while capitalizing upon the narratological tropes of Hindu myths, simultaneously subdue, if not empty, those myths of their ideological workings. From gender relations to social hierarchy, all the mythical inconveniences vanish into thin air in favor of archetypal tropes of "Good vs. Evil" (A good litmus

test to test these novels remains the question of caste within their narrative). One can only wonder whether it is the writer's imagination or the capitalist marketplace that is responsible for this leveling of concrete inconveniences in favor of abstract archetypes.

Another characteristic about the form of these narratives is their seriality. From Tripathi's *The Immortals of Meluha*, which became a three-part series just like his recent "Ram Chandra" series, to Komarraju's "Hastinapur" series, Krishna Udayashankar's *The Aryavarta Chronicles* trilogy, Kevin Missal's *Kalki* trilogy, and Akshat Gupta's *The Hidden Hindu* trilogy, these narratives are designed in a way that accommodates both future continuation and possible adaptation into visual media. It is precisely here that we not only see the extent to which the mythological fiction parts its way from the "myths" that it promises to re-write (after all, myths are self-contained narratives, and there is no Vyasa multi-verse), but, we can simultaneously sense the forces of 21st-century literary marketplace around every narrative turn and behind the back of every narrative character.

While both of these observations—the evacuation of history *and* the market-driven serial form of narrative—highlight the sites of metamorphosis in the systems of representation, none of them, by itself, tells us much about the impacts this representational metamorphosis entails. It is only in taking these observations in conjunction with each other, i.e., treating "the evacuation of history" *as* one of the dictates for thriving in the literary marketplace and the emergence of seriality *as* a historical form that opened the gates, or pages, of the novels to the invisible hand of the market, that we can begin to fathom the impacts of the 21st century literary markets upon the representational forms of contemporary mythological fictions.

I began this essay by juxtaposing Derrida's remark on the "end of the book" with the phenomena of "national bestsellers," and it is with Derrida that I would like to end. Can we say if Derrida was right in his pronouncement after all? Derrida's diagnosis about the "end of the book" *as*

an end of the bounded totality seems to have manifested at two simultaneous level: firstly, at the level of their form, particularly in their seriality which makes them ‘open’ towards future of working and re-workings, and secondly, at the level of their content, particularly in the way that these novels themselves have opened-up and re-worked ancient myths/religious stories, and have adapted them for ‘our’ market-driven capitalist time. But that is not all.

The forces that have inserted a wedge between the bindings of the ‘book,’ the forces that have exerted pressure over the system of representation, are forces powered by the (literary-) marketplace in its allure of making a novel “best-seller” with the further promise of converting it to a media object (as I write this, [the most expensive Bollywood movie, based on an ancient epic *Ramayana*](#) is in post-production). The paradox then is not that the ‘end of the book’ has come with the emergence of ‘national bestsellers,’ but rather, that the ‘end of book’ has manifested *not* as a surmounting but rather as negating of the history of literature—abandoning us, to use Derrida’s phrase, [“adrift in the threat of limitlessness.”](#)

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